

Summary - Documentation Best Practices

- Principal Diagnosis
- Capture all conditions that are present on admission that are being evaluated and managed
- Capture the highest specificity and acuity appropriate for each diagnosis
- Link all diagnoses to their underlying causes, manifestations, pathophysiology; support with clinical indicators and treatment
- Indicate type, acuity, severity and specificity of all diagnoses
- Link symptoms and signs, lab/dx tests, pathology results to underlying diagnosis, when confirmed or presumed and specify clinical significance
- Capture uncertain conditions with terms such as “suspected”, “likely”, or “probable”
- Resolve or rule out diagnoses before removing them from your documentation
- Capture comorbid and major comorbid conditions
- Embed clinical condition risk indicators
- Document medication compliance; Alcohol and tobacco abuse
- Write a clear, concise, consistent discharge summary that summarizes the entire hospital course

Documentation should reflect your critical decision making for each diagnosis; prior treatment measures; patient limitations and safety concerns